

the canal to the side of the palm support. When using this device, you would never have to lift your hand from the palm rest. Mastering this device takes a long time though.

The TouchStream LP lets you type using gestures. Incorporating a technology called MultiTouch, this device has the ability to detect multiple points of contact as well as detect patterns in their movement (or lack of movement). On recognising a gesture, the TouchStream LP will apply whatever behaviour has been assigned to that touch and movement pattern. The gesture recognition is accomplished on the same flat area that the keyboard is mapped on. In a nutshell, it enables a user to type, point and perform simple gestures, all on one surface.

Speech Recognition

Researchers have been working for a long time on alternatives to conventional modes of input. Although features such as speech and handwriting recognition are not new, they have just started to become mainstream and you can find these on devices such as tablet PCs.

Over the past few years, many vendors have come up with software products that can recognise the spoken word, but most of them have died out. Imagine speaking normally to your PC and having your words appear on the screen. The objective of accurate speech recognition has existed for a long time, but only recently has the dream become a possible reality.

Are we there? Not yet. Are we getting there? Sure! Depending on whether you use Windows XP, Microsoft Office's built-in speech engine or a third-party speech engine, ease of use, accuracy, and enjoyment of the feature may vary.

IBM and Dragon Naturally Speaking are two large companies involved in the development of speech recognition technology. Microsoft's Windows XP and Office applications incorporate this feature. The Tablet edition of Windows XP has significant improvements in this regard, and though complete accuracy is still difficult to achieve, users can look forward to exciting times ahead. Not only is this feature extremely useful for normal users, it also opens up a lot of options for the disabled.

In Windows XP, you can use either the Speech Recognition tab or the Text-

to-Speech tab in Speech properties to initialise and customise speech-enabled applications. These settings control general attributes such as input and output devices, the language used, as well as the playback voice and the accuracy of word recognition.

You can choose between several preferential option settings and customise the speech profile according to your needs. You can also create a new profile or set a profile to accommodate your speaking style. A new Recognizer Profile should be created if you move offices, the noise level changes on a permanent basis, or additional people are present.

Training allows the speech recogniser to adapt to the sound of your voice, word pronunciation, accent and speaking manner. This is done through the Voice Training Wizard. Training for even a short period can effect an improvement in the accuracy of speech recognition. The system also adapts to your speech on an ongoing basis, and recognition increases over time.



Handwriting Recognition

The Windows XP Tablet PC offers major improvements in handwriting recognition. You can write directly on the screen with a stylus, and what you write is converted to text that can be inserted into applications such as MS Word and Notepad. Consider the convenience of taking notes in meetings or conferences in your own handwriting, converting them to text later and e-mailing them to people. It's not only this convenient, but quite accurate too.

You can use handwriting recognition in programs that support it. These include Internet Explorer 5.0 or later, where you can use handwriting in text boxes that appear on Web sites, but not in the address bar; and Outlook Express 5.0 or later. In addition, all Microsoft Office XP programs, such as Microsoft Word 2002 or Microsoft Outlook 2002, and any other software program that is enabled to use the Microsoft handwriting recognition engine. To use handwriting recognition, you must first install a handwriting recognition engine, which is language-specific.